

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Medium

CORE FORMULA

State the conclusion -> Give one reason -> Offer context if asked

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before speaking or writing, ask: 'What is the one thing I want them to take away?' Say that first.

BEST FOR

- Presenting to senior stakeholders or decision-makers
- Written communication — emails, messages, reports
- Answering questions where context buries the point
- Any communication where the other person has limited time

PHRASE BANK

BLUF Openers · Leading with the conclusion

- "Bottom line: I recommend..."
- "The short answer is..."
- "My conclusion is... — I can explain why if useful."
- "The decision is..."
- "Up front: ..."
- "The answer is yes, with one condition."
- "The answer is no, and here is the reason."
- "My recommendation: ..."

Context Offers · Adding detail without burying the lead

- "I can give you the background if you need it."
- "That is the headline — want the detail?"
- "Short version or longer version?"
- "The reasoning is straightforward — want me to walk through it?"
- "Happy to elaborate on any of that."
- "Three bullet points behind that if it helps."

Everyday BLUF · Fast answers in casual moments

- "Short answer: yes."
- "Short answer: no. Long answer available."
- "Quick version: it worked."
- "Headline first: we got it."
- "One-liner: it is done, two small caveats."

Written BLUF · First lines for emails and messages

- "Decision needed: X or Y, by Friday."
- "Action for you: review section two by Thursday."
- "FYI only — no action needed: the launch moved to Monday."
- "Requesting sign-off on the attached. Deadline is Wednesday."
- "Summary up front: we are on track, one risk flagged below."
- "This email asks one question: can we move the deadline?"

On-the-Spot BLUF · When a senior person asks you cold

- "My answer is yes — with one condition I want to flag."
- "The one thing you need to know is this."
- "Bottom line first, then I will take questions."
- "If you only take one thing from this: X."
- "My position in one sentence: we should proceed."
- "I will give you the headline now and the detail in writing."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Long preamble then the actual request at the end
Better: I have a request — [context] — could you...?
Best: 'I need X by Thursday. Here is why.' Context in one line after.
2. Weak: Answering a question with 'well, it depends...' before the answer
Better: There are a few factors, but generally...
Best: The answer is X. The main caveat is Y.
3. Weak: Email that starts with 'Hope you're well, I wanted to reach out about...'
Better: I'm reaching out because...
Best: I need your input on X. Background below.

DECISION TREE

If You are about to explain a long context before the point

Stop. State the point first. Then offer the context.
"The short answer is X. The context behind that is..."

If Someone asks you a question

Answer the question directly in the first sentence.
"Yes. / No. / My view is X."

If You are writing an email with multiple paragraphs before the ask

Move the ask to the first line.
"I need your sign-off on X by Thursday. Context below."

If The topic is complex and you feel you need to build up

Give a one-sentence executive summary first, then build.
"Summary: we are on track / off track / need a decision. Detail below."

If You bury the point and the person asks 'so what is the bottom line?'

Take that as a signal. Next time, start there.
"You are right — the point is: ..."

SCENARIOS

Senior exec asks for your view in a meeting

One sentence answer. Then offer to elaborate. — "My recommendation is X. The main reason is Y. Want the detail?"

You are presenting a project update

Status first. Then key risks. Then any decisions needed. — "We are on track for the deadline. One risk I want to flag."

Writing a message asking for help

State the ask in the first line. — "Can you review this by Tuesday? I've attached the doc."

Job interview: 'Tell me about yourself'

One sentence summary. Then context. Not the reverse. — "I am a [role] with [years] focused on [thing]. Let me give you the context."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When delivering bad news that requires emotional preparation before the conclusion.
- In high-stakes persuasion where building context first changes how the audience receives your point.

- When the audience genuinely needs background to evaluate the bottom line — give the bottom line, then immediately offer the context.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the buried lead

In every email you write today, find the main point and move it to line one.

Day 2 — Answer first

Every time someone asks you a question today, answer it in the first sentence.

Day 3 — The one-sentence test

Before any communication, ask: 'Can I say this in one sentence?' If yes, do that first.

Day 4 — Verbal BLUF

In one meeting, state your conclusion before your reasoning. Notice the reaction.

Day 5 — Offer context, don't force it

After your bottom line, offer the context rather than giving it automatically.

Day 6 — Written practice

Rewrite one email you sent this week to lead with the ask. Notice the difference.

Day 7 — Calibration

Was your communication clearer? Did people respond faster? Was anything lost by leading with the conclusion?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state the conclusion or recommendation first?
- Did I answer the question in the first sentence?
- Did I offer context rather than force it?
- Did I avoid starting with background or preamble?
- Was my bottom line clear in one sentence?
- Did I check whether the context was actually needed?
- Did I avoid using BLUF when the situation required care before directness (e.g. bad news)?